Romanians, who had begun to distance themselves from Moscow after Khrushchev's withdrawal of Soviet Army units from their country in 1958 began and had refused to side with the Soviet leader in his conflict with Mao Zedong.[4]

But the bullying tactics no longer worked. Kennedy was proceeding to implement the blockade, and Khrushchev was at a loss to respond effectively. The boomerang of nuclear war with which Khrushchev threatened Kennedy was coming back to haunt him. Vasilii Kuznetsov, the Soviet deputy foreign minister in charge of Soviet-American relations, told a trusted colleague that in the first days after Kennedy's television address, the Moscow leadership was paralyzed by "the confusion that reigned there, which was only covered up by Khrushchev's blustering public statements." In reality, continued Kuznetsov, "from the very beginning of the crisis, fear of the possible course of further developments arose within the Soviet leadership and increased with every passing hour."[5]

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THE ROMANIANS LEFT MOSCOW ON OCTOBER 24, THE DAY after their arrival, but not before Gheorghiu-Dej witnessed another of Khrushchev's outbursts. The Soviet leader was having breakfast with his Romanian guests when he received a report from the head of the KGB, Vladimir Semichastny. According to a decoded cable, Kennedy had canceled his planned visit to Brazil and was ordering the imposition of a naval blockade of Cuba. Khrushchev's face grew red as he read the cable. He started cursing "like a bargeman," threw the paper on the floor, and stamped on it with his heel. "That's how I'm going to crush that viper," he shouted, also calling Kennedy a "millionaire's whore." "If Kennedy had been there, the lunatic would have strangled him dead on the spot," Gheorghiu-Dej told his assistants upon his return to Bucharest.[6]

Gheorghiu-Dej was not the only foreign visitor whom Khrushchev met on October 24. Another was the president of the Westinghouse Electric International Company, William E. Knox. A prominent businessman who had managed his company's relations with the Soviet foreign trade agency,